The Lake at Dawn

The sky was just beginning to lighten, the faintest hint of orange brushing against the deep blue of the early dawn. Eluru was still asleep, its streets quiet, the lake's surface smooth like glass. It was Krishna's favourite time of day—the soft hush before the world woke up. And this morning, he was a little early for his usual walk. Perhaps, he thought, destiny had something in store.

The gentle breeze carried the faint scent of water and wet earth as he approached the lake, his hands tucked into the pockets of his jacket. That's when he saw him.

A boy, maybe seventeen or eighteen, stood near the edge of the water, his posture stiff, shoulders hunched as if bearing a weight too heavy. His eyes were fixed on the stillness of the lake, but Krishna saw something darker in them—something final.

Krishna didn't hesitate. He walked up slowly, careful not to startle him.

"Hey," Krishna said, his voice calm but firm. "What are you doing here this early?".

The boy didn't move. Silence stretched thin between them.

Then, barely audible, the boy replied, "Nothing."

Krishna stepped closer. "Nothing? At the edge of the lake? That's not nothing."

Krishna took another slow step. "What's your name?".

The boy hesitated, then muttered, "Arjun.".

"Arjun," Krishna repeated. "I'm Krishna.".

The boy's jaw tightened. "Go away."

Krishna didn't. He stood beside him, staring out at the water. Krishna noticed Arjun's hands tremble—barely, but enough to speak volumes. Krishna took a deep breath.

"You don't have to do this," he said.

"You don't know anything about me," Arjun snapped.

Krishna didn't flinch. He kept his voice calm, measured.

"You're right, Arjun. I don't know your story. But I see you. I see the pain in your eyes, the weight on your shoulders.

And I know that sometimes, just being seen, just having someone acknowledge that weight, can make a difference.”.

He paused, letting the silence settle again, the only sound the gentle lapping of the water.

“Look at the lake, Arjun. It’s still, but it’s deep. It holds a lot. Just like you. You’re holding a lot inside. But even deep water reflects the light. And the light is coming, Arjun. The sun's about to break through.”.

Krishna shifted slightly, his gaze unwavering.

“You don’t have to carry this alone, not right now. You don't have to make any permanent decisions based on a temporary feeling.”.

He took another small step closer, not crowding Arjun, but bridging the gap between them.

"Just breathe with me, Arjun. One breath at a time. Let the silence be here, let the feeling be here, but don't let it take you."

He offered a small, gentle smile.

"Even the darkest night gives way to dawn. And dawn is coming."

Krishna placed a hand on Arjun’s shoulder.

“You can. You just need to breathe today. And tomorrow. And the day after. You’ll figure it out.”

Arjun shook his head. Krishna squeezed his shoulder.

“Come on,” he said quietly. “Let’s sit.”

As the sun finally broke through the horizon, its golden light spilled over the lake, painting everything in hues of quiet hope. Krishna led Arjun away from the edge, their footsteps slow but steady.

They sat down on a bench not far from the water, the silence between them no longer heavy, but healing. Arjun wiped his eyes roughly with his sleeve.

“Why do you care?” he asked, voice raw.

Krishna looked at him, then back at the lake. For a long moment, he didn’t answer. Then, softly, he said, “Because once… I stood where you are.”

Arjun turned slightly, confused. Krishna’s gaze remained fixed on the shimmering water.

“There was a girl. Radha. She changed everything. And then… she left. Or maybe I pushed her away. I don’t know anymore.”

A shadow passed over his face, old pain flickering behind his eyes.

“I don’t talk about it often,” he continued, voice steady despite the ache beneath. “But maybe… it’s time.”

He glanced at Arjun, a small, tired smile on his lips.

“You saved me from my silence, Arjun. Maybe it’s only fair I try to return the favour.”

And just like that, the story began—not of a saviour—but of a boy who once believed in forever, and the girl who taught him what it meant to lose.